Don't go — or you'll lose me on your way



● MELBOURNE personality and columnist Keith Dunstan has always been a Kim Hughes man — even after Hughes last year quit the pinnacle of the game, Captain of Australia. Now that Hughes seems certain to lead a team of cricket rebels to South Africa, Dunstan has written him an open letter serving notice that it will mean the end of their affair.



Keith Dunstan

MELBOURNE

Dear Kim Hughes,

I am a cricket fanatic. I read every word that is printed on the subject.

I love the game so much that, to the misery of my family, I have it turned on by the hour. I am one of those extraordinary eccentrics who take it in marathon sessions.

You have given me countless hours of pleasure. Your cover drive is beautiful to see, certainly as artistic and wonderful as that *Streeton* which went for nearly $1 million last week.

However, when you go to South Africa I hope there are no broadcasts, no television. I hope that no Australian correspondent will go to look at your play and I hope, particularly, that this newspaper does not even print the scores.

'Free agents'

I for one will not want to know them.

Harsh judgment? I don't think so.

What you are doing now you will regret all your life.

Certainly we have known about the South African tour for four months now, but you provided the line that disturbed me last week more than anything.

When the court action between the Australian Cricket Board and the South African Cricket Union was settled out of court, you cried: "We've won. We're free agents. Fabulous news."

Did you also note the comments of Bishop Desmond Tutu, the black leader, who said: "It is an obscenity. They should have the decency to speak the truth and say they have sold themselves."

Oh yes, fabulous news, you along with great names like Yallop, Hogg, Rackemann, Dyson and Alderman are banned from representing Australia for three years. I don't think anyone is going to forget that easily.

I also read that two more prominent cricketers have joined the tour for $250,000 each.

That's an impressive figure, money beyond the dreams of most of us. But some people have higher values.

Weapon

Are you all getting a quarter of a million? Let's see, if there are 16 of you that makes a nice round $4 million, doesn't it? The out-of-court settlement cost the South Africans $120,000.

I imagine hotel expenses, travelling expenses and, oh yes, police protection will be very expensive. What will be the overall cost of this South African tour? — $8 million? $10 million?

How much would you say the South Africans are spending right this minute on teaching cricket to black South African children?

Whenever you talk to sports people about South Africa, they come back with two arguments. (a) You should keep politics out of sport. (b) Why pick on us? What about all the trade with South Africa?

Alas, you can't keep politics out of sport, politics is life, and as for trade, until now it has not been a good weapon.

The argument that it is hypocritical to trade with South Africa and at the same time refuse to play football and cricket is far too simplistic.

You see, a sports boycott works, and almost invariably a trade boycott does not. South Africa trades with Ghana and Russia and Chile and Czechoslovakia. It is quite surprising how far our friends of the Eastern bloc will go.

There are not so many who play cricket or Rugby Union or golf or bowls. The South Africans are just as obsessed with sport as we are. Why do you think they are prepared to pay millions for our — begging your pardon — second XI?

They are very good indeed at sport, as you know. They depend on it for publicity and national prestige.

And make no mistake, when the blacks see you, Kim Hughes, one of the greatest cricketers of them all, turning up on the white playing fields, they will feel their cause is being defeated.

Illusion

I have a friend, Colin Tatz, Professor of Politics at Macquarie University. He was born and educated in South Africa. He has written a paper titled *Sport in South Africa*.

There a number of points that would interest you. He says that the spending on a rebel Soccer tour was 2 million rand. The amount of money spent over the same period on sport for 3,600,000 black children was 15,000 rand.

He says the South African Government has gone to great lengths to give black-white sport a fig leaf of respectability. In 1980 the Government allowed sports clubs to apply for international status which would allow them to sell liquor and food to a visiting black competitor, a black official or a guest of a member.

But it is an illusion. In promoting school sports the rate of spending for white schools is 340 times that of the black rate.

He claims that if you go to Langa, in Cape Town, there is one Soccer field for 36 teams. Or you can search in vain for any facility in Port Elizabeth's Little Soweto.

You are a very popular figure, and I know I am in a minority when I ask you not to go. Incredibly, a recent public opinion poll made it very clear that you are going to South Africa with Australia's blessing.

Perhaps this says more about comfortable, affluent, white Australia than it says about Kim Hughes.

I thought it one of the most appalling results I have seen from an Australian poll.

Please don't think I am anti-Hughes. I gave a great cry of pain when last year they virtually forced you out of the captaincy.

Your action resulting in a three-year ban is a calamity. Stay with us, Kim, and your return to the Australian side will be as inevitable as the dawn.

Yours sincerely,
Keith Dunstan.

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